The Zoo Story

By Edward Albee

INTRODUCTION

The Zoo Story by Edward Albee is a confrontation between middle-class America and the outcasts of society. Set in central park, Peter, an average American, is confronted by Jerry, a lonely man from the wrong side of the park. Jerry tries to teach Peter the realities of life that Peter has tried to ignore. He tries to teach Peter the nature of human existence and relationships. Through a serious of failed conversations and misinterpretations of the act of love, Jerry begins his experiment to see if the middle class Americas are animals after all. The Zoo Story by Edward Albee.

JERRY: *[mysteriously]* Peter, do you want to know what happened at the zoo?

PETER: Ah, ha, ha. The what? Oh yes: the zoo. Oh, ho, . . . hee, hee, the parakeets getting dinner ready, and the . . .ha, ha, whatever it was, the . .

JERRY: *[calmly]* Yes, that was very funny, Peter. I wouldn't have expected it. But do you want to hear about what happened at the zoo, or not?

PETER: Yes. - Yes, by all means; tell me what happened at the zoo. Oh, my. I don't know what happened to me.

JERRY: Now I'll let you in on what happened at the zoo; but first, I should tell you why I went to the zoo. I went to the zoo to find out more about the way people exist with animals, and the way animals exist with each other and with people too. It probably wasn't a fair test, what with everyone separated by bars from everyone else, the animals for the most part from each other, and always the people from the animals. But if it's a zoo, that's the way it is. [He pokes Peter on the arm.] Move over.

PETER: *[friendly]:* I'm sorry, haven't you enough room? *[He shifts a little.]*

JERRY: *[smiling slightly]:* Well, all the animals are there, and all the people are there, and it's Sunday and all the children are there. *[He pokes Peter again.]* Move over.

PETER: *[patiently, still friendly]:* All right. *[He moves some more, and Jerry has all the room he might need.]*

JERRY: It's a hot day, so all the stench is there, too, and all the balloon sellers, and all the ice cream sellers, and all the seals are barking, and all the birds are screaming. *[Pokes Peter harder.]* Move over!

PETER: *[beginning to be annoyed]:* Look here, you have more than enough room! *[But he moves more, and is now fairly cramped at one end of the bench.]*

JERRY: And I am there, and it's feeding time at the lions' house, and the lion keeper comes into the lion cage, one of the lion cages, to feed one of the lions. *[Punches Peter on the arm, hard.]* MOVE OVER!

PETER: *[very annoyed]:* I can't move over any more, and stop hitting me. What's the matter with you?

JERRY: Do you want to hear the story? *[Punches Peter's arm again.]*

PETER: *[flabbergasted].* I'm not so sure! I certainly don't want to be punched in the arm.

JERRY: Listen to me, Peter I want this bench. You go sit on the bench over there, and if you're good I'll tell you the rest of the story.

PETER: *[flustered]:* But . . . whatever for? What is the matter with you? Besides, I see no reason why I should give up this bench. I sit on this bench almost every Sunday afternoon, in good weather. It's secluded here; there's never anyone sitting here, so I have it all to myself.

JERRY: I said I want this bench, and I'm going to have it. Now get over there.

PETER: People can't have everything they want. You should know that; it's a rule; people can have some of the things they want, but they can't have everything.

JERRY: *[laughs]:* Imbecile! You're slow-witted! *[pushes Peter almost, but not quite, off the bench]:* Get out of my sight.

PETER: *[regaining his position]:* God da . . . mn you. That's enough! I've had enough of you. I will not give up this bench; you can't have it, and that's that. Now, go away. *[Jerry snorts but does not move.]* Go away, I said. *[Jerry does not move.]* Get away from here. If you don't move on . . . you're a bum . . . that's what you are . . . If you don't move on, I'll get a policeman here and make you go. *[Jerry laughs, stays.]* I warn you, I'll call a policeman.

JERRY: *[softly]:* You won't find a policeman around here; they're all over on the west side of the park chasing fairies down from trees or out of the bushes. That's all they do. That's their function. So scream your head off; it won't do you any good.

PETER: POLICE! I warn you, I'll have you arrested. POLICE! *[Pause.]* I said POLICE! *[Pause.]* I feel ridiculous.

JERRY: You look ridiculous: a grown man screaming for the police on a bright Sunday afternoon in the park with nobody harming you. If a policeman did fill his quota and come sludging over this way he's probably take you in as a nut.

JERRY: Do you know how ridiculous you look now?

PETER: *[his fury and self-consciousness have possessed him]* It doesn't matter. *[He is almost crying.]* GET AWAY FROM MY BENCH!

JERRY: Why? You have everything in the world you want; you've told me about your home, and your family, and your own little zoo. You have everything, and now you want this bench. Are these the things men fight for? Can you think of anything more absurd?

PETER: Absurd? Look, I'm not going to talk to you about honor, or even try to explain it to you. Besides, it isn't a question of honor; but even if it were, you wouldn't understand.

JERRY: *[contemptuously]:* You don't even know what you're saying, do you? This is probably the first time in your life you've had anything more trying to face than changing your cats' toilet box. Stupid! Don't you have any idea, not even the slightest, what other people need?

PETER: Oh, boy, listen to you; well, you don't need this bench. That's for sure.

JERRY: Yes; yes, I do.

PETER: *[quivering].* I've come here for years; I have hours of great pleasure, great satisfaction, right here. And that's important to a man. I'm a responsible person, and I'm a GROWNUP. This is my bench, and you have no right to take it away from me.

JERRY: Fight for it, then. Defend yourself; defend your bench.

PETER: You've pushed me to it. Get up and fight.

JERRY: *[rises lazily]:* Very well, Peter, we'll battle for the bench, but we're not evenly matched. *[He takes out and clicks open an ugly looking knife.]*

PETER: *[suddenly awakening to the reality of the situation]:* You are mad! You're stark raving mad! YOU'RE GOING TO KILL ME! *[But before Peter has time to think what to do, Jerry tosses the knife at Peter's feet.]*

JERRY: There you go. Pick it up. You have the knife and we'll be more evenly matched.

PETER: *[horrified]:* No!

JERRY: *[rushes over to Peter grabs him by the collar; Peter rises; their faces almost touch]:* Now you pick up that knife and you fight with me. You fight for your self-respect; you fight for that goddamned bench.

PETER: *[struggling]:* No! Let . . . let go of me! He . . . Help!

JERRY: *[slaps Peter on each "fight"]:* You fight, you miserable bastard; fight for that bench; fight for your parakeets; fight for your cats, fight for your two daughters; fight for your wife; fight for your manhood, you pathetic little vegetable. *[Spits in Peter's face.]* You couldn't even get your wife with a male child.

PETER: *[breaks away, enraged]:* It's a matter of genetics, no manhood, you . . . you monster. *[He darts down, picks up the knife and backs off a little; he is breathing heavily.]* I'll give you one last chance; get out of here and leave me alone! *[He holds the knife with a firm arm, but far in front of him, not to attack, but to defend.]*

JERRY: *[sighs heavily].* So be it! *[With a rush he charges Peter and impales himself on the knife. Tableau: For just a moment, complete silence, Jerry impaled on the knife at the end of Peter's still firm arm. Then Peter screams, pulls away, leaving the knife in Jerry. Jerry is motionless, on point. Then he, too, screams, and it must be the sound of an infuriated and fatally wounded animal. With the knife in him, he stumbles back to the bench that Peter has vacated. He crumbles there, sitting, facing Peter his eyes wide in agony, his mouth open.]*

PETER: *[whispering]:* Oh my God, oh my God, oh my God . . . *[He repeats these words man times, very rapidly.]*

JERRY: *[Jerry is dying; but now his expression seems to change. His features relax, and while his voice varies, sometimes wrenched with pain, for the most part he seems removed from his dying. He smiles]:* Thank you, Peter. I mean that, now; thank you very much. *[Peter's mouth drops open. He cannot move; he is transfixed.]* Oh, Peter, I was so afraid I'd drive you away. *[He laughs as best he can.]* You don't know how afraid I was you'd go away and leave me. And now I'll tell you what happened at the zoo. I think . . . I think this is what happened at the zoo. I think. I think that while I was at the zoo I decided that I would walk north . . . northerly, rather . . . until I found you . . . or somebody . . . and I decided that I would talk to you . . . I would tell you things . . . and things that I would tell you would . . . Well, here we are. You see? Here we are. But . . . I don't . . . could I have planned all this? No . . . no, I couldn't have. But I think I did. And now I've told you what you wanted to know, haven't I? And now you know all about what happened at the zoo. And now you know what you'll see in your TV, and the face I told you about . . . you remember . . . the face I told you about . . . my face, the face you see right now. Peter. . . Peter? . . . Peter . . . thank you. I came unto you *[He laughs, so faintly.]* and you have comforted me. Dear Peter.

PETER: *[almost fainting]:* Oh my God!

JERRY: You'd better go now. Somebody might come by, and you don't want to be here when anyone comes.

PETER: *[does not move, but begins to weep]:* Oh my God, oh my God.

JERRY: *[most faintly, now; he is very near death]:* You won't be coming back here any more, Peter; you've been dispossessed. You've lost your bench, but you've

defended your honor. And Peter, I'll tell you something now; you're not really a vegetable; it's all right, you're an animal. You're an animal, too. But you'd better hurry now, Peter. Hurry, you'd better go . . . see? *[Jerry takes a handkerchief and with great effort and pain wipes the knife handle clean of fingerprints.]* Hurry away, Peter. *[Peter begins to stagger away.]* Wait . . . wait Peter. Take your book . . . book. Right here . . . beside me . . . on your bench . . . my bench, rather. Come . . . take your book. *[Peter starts for the book, but retreats.]* Hurry . . . Peter. *[Peter rushes to the bench, grabs the book, retreats.]* Very good, Peter. . . very good. Now . . . hurry away. *[Peter hesitates for a moment, then flees, stage left.]* Hurry away . . . *[His eyes are closed now.]* Hurry away, your parakeets are making the dinner . . . the cats . . . are setting the table . . .

PETER: *[off stage, a pitiful howl]:* OH MY GOD!

JERRY: *[his eyes still closed, he shakes his head and speaks; a combination of scornful mimicry and supplication]:* Oh . . . my . . . God. *[He is dead.]*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARDS

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